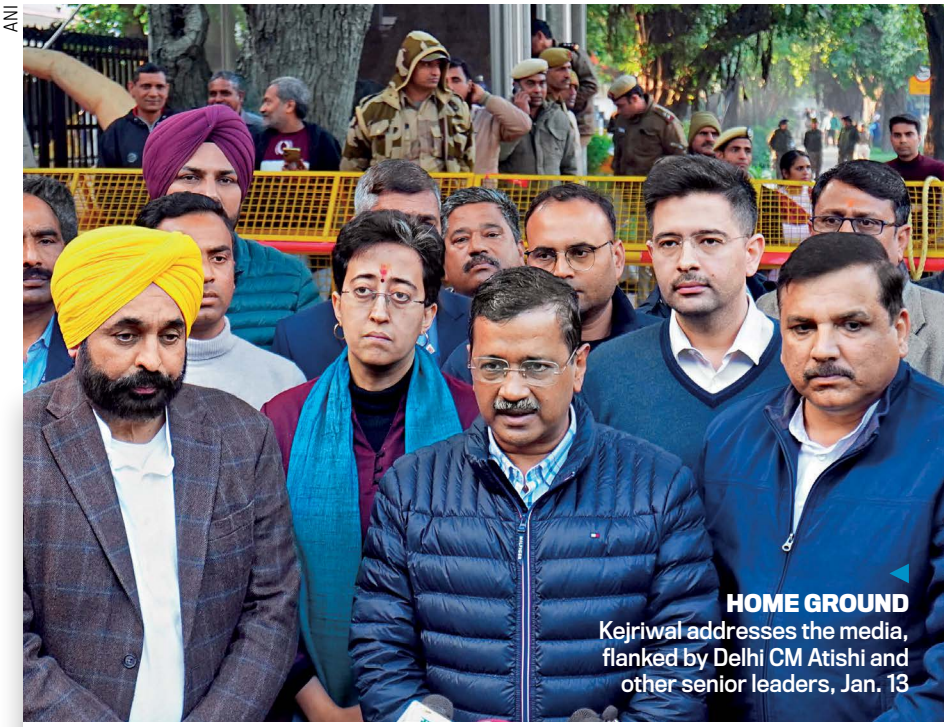
or a gilded glass palace. Internal rifts, high-profile defections and criticism over its governance model have shaken AAP's foundation, making Kejriwal's a fight not just against his opponents but also one for his very political survival. The AAP leader has to battle not just the ghost of anti-incumbency but also the severe dent to his old image as an anti-corruption crusader. The hardest blow came when the Enforcement Directorate (ED) arrested him in March 2024 for his alleged involvement in a multi-crore money-laundering liquor policy scam and sent to judicial custody, the first ever sitting chief minister to face that fate. When the Supreme Court granted him bail in September 2024 after he spent more than five months in jail, he resigned as chief minister, saying, "I got justice from the legal court, now I will get justice from the people's court."

THE KEJRIWAL FACTOR

When AAP first came to power on the back of the anti-corruption movement in 2013, Kejriwal was seen as the messiah of the common man who would drain the bloated swamp of corruption that had enveloped Indian politics. After a short 49-day stint as chief minister in alliance with the Congress party, Kejriwal resigned, citing resistance against the radical anti-corruption legislation he had proposed. Plotting his return in the 2015 assembly polls, he projected himself as the saviour of the poor, reducing the electricity per unit charges by half and providing 20,000 litres of water free of cost in addition to improving health and education facilities. AAP swept that election, winning 67 out of Delhi's 70 assembly seats with a vote share of 54 per cent, decimating both the BJP and the Congress in the process. Kejriwal's commitment to cleanse politics and bring more accountability to governance had appealed to the elite and the upper middle class, while his pro-people agenda, including a quasi-universal basic income via freebies, attracted the lower middle class and the poorer population of Delhi. In the 2020 assembly polls, AAP did an encore, with a marginally reduced tally of 62 seats but retaining the vote share. This was despite the BJP winning all seven parliamentary seats in Delhi in the 2019 Lok Sabha election like it had in 2014.

And while Kejriwal's bid to extend his unique model of governance beyond the national capital may have come a cropper in Goa, AAP did create some ripples in Gujarat and reached its zenith in Punjab, when it won 92 of its 117 assembly seats in the March 2022 assembly polls. Having scaled these peaks, however, AAP's aura has only been diminishing, especially in Delhi, after the BJP went hammer and tongs at it to puncture its growing national acceptability. The ED brought charges of corruption against Kejriwal and his deputy, Manish Sisodia, which saw the duo spend time in jail before getting bail. Other senior leaders, including former transport minister Kai-

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HOME GROUND Kejriwal addresses the media, flanked by Delhi CM Atishi and other senior leaders, Jan. 13

AAP GAME PLAN

Key features of the party's electoral strategy

- **SOMETHING FOR EVERYBODY: Tailored welfare benefits for all, from women, youth and senior citizens to auto-rickshaw drivers, slum-dwellers and sanitation workers to 'Purvanchalis' and Dalits**
- **FOCUSED CAMPAIGN: Concentration on seats won or lost with narrow margins (<5,000-10,000 votes) with sustained, granular, door-to-door campaigns, padayatras, rallies and roadshows**
- **HIGHLIGHT THE BJP'S SHORTCOMINGS: The lack of a CM face for one. Use Union budget to highlight party's political pain-points—from jobs, tax slabs for middle class to GST**
- **NO OVERT MUSLIM MESSAGING: Peddling soft Hindutva instead, from chanting the 'Hanuman Chalisa' to visiting temples**
- **DATA ANALYTICS: Ground surveys and reports deployed to fine-tune campaign tactics. Shifted focus to middle-class voters towards the latter half of the campaign, for instance, based on ground surveys**
- **CLEVER USE OF MULTIMEDIA: From movies to books to social media, constant attempt to set record straight on Opposition allegations like Liquorgate or Sheesh Mahal, and to highlight AAP's signature welfare programmes**

Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY